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How Reviewing on Letterboxd Transforms Movie Consumption Experiences

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Abstract

This thesis examines how online movie reviewing can transform consumption experiences. While existing marketing research has primarily treated movie reviews as predictive outputs for box office performance, little is known about the experiential effects of reviewing on consumers themselves. A multi-level model of a reviewing practice (Figure 1) is created using Consumer Culture Theory (CCT) and the Associative-Propositional Evaluation (APE) model.

Empirical materials were collected through netnography on Letterboxd and semi-structured interviews with 13 active users, resulting in 260 user reviews and approximately 16 hours of interview data.

Thematic analysis identified three transformational outcomes. First, online reviewing prolongs a movie consumption experience through affective and cognitive pathways. Second, reviews can function as temporal anchors that make episodic traces visible and revisitable. Third, online reviewing necessitates the performance of movie consumer identities, which actively changes consumer ideologies and the marketplace culture. The findings demonstrate that an online movie reviewing practice affects consumption experiences.

This thesis contributes a consumer-centric perspective to movie marketing research, by reorienting attention from financial outcomes to experiential transformations,

Keywords: online reviewing, art consumption, movie marketing, CCT, APE model, netnography, Letterboxd

Introduction

How do consumers understand art consumption experiences? An art consumption experience, as defined by Holbrook & Hirschman (1982) and Lemon & Verhoef (2016), is an extended, multi-phase process, which encompasses anticipation, live experience and reflection. This means that an art consumption experience does not end after visiting a museum or seeing a movie in a cinema. The consumption of art continues after the initial viewing, as opinions form, personal meanings emerge, and memories are reconstructed (Nigatu et al., 2024). Art is then consumed not with one singular encounter, but rather through an ongoing process of interpretation and re-interpretation.

To provide a glimpse into how art consumption experiences are being understood, Schneider et al., (2021) refer to art (re-)interpretations as a collection of evaluations. Schneider et al. (2021) do also provide the caveat that researching written evaluations only reveal the outcome of the interpretive process but not the actual process itself. Hence, it is helpful to engage with Arnould and Thompson's (2005) CCT framework, which provides possible reasoning as to how cultural aspects shape the interpretive evaluation process of art consumption experiences. The need to *review* consumer evaluations is perhaps expressed most clearly in this quote by Gawronski (2007, p. 579):

"Evaluative responses play a significant role—if not the most significant role—for understanding social behavior."

Examining the practice of online movie reviewing is well suited for uncovering art consumption experiences, because of the multitude of possible evaluative outcomes related to film consumption. From the plethora of subjects that written consumer evaluations can cover, movies are both works of art and entertainment. This means that movie reviews consist of multifaceted evaluations, ranging "from a spontaneous sense of liking or disliking to well-founded critique" (Schneider et al., 2021, p. 584). Furthermore, when movie evaluations are expressed online they impact other consumers (Chintagunta et al., 2010), which shows how online reviewing is a constitutive part of CCT.

Letterboxd was selected as the thesis' research site since it has an established movie review culture, and a vibrant user base. The New York Times Magazine characterizes Letterboxd as "a cinephilic hive buzzing with authentic enthusiasm and heterogeneous tastes" (Kleeman, 2026). The user base consists of independent cinema enthusiasts, making it a concentrated site of consumer culture and diverse opinions. Letterboxd users are prompted/encouraged to create text-based reviews, the lengths of which range from "ultrashort, off-the-cuff takes to gonzo film-theory-inflected texts" (Kleeman, 2026). This is distinct from other platforms like Rotten

Tomatoes and IMDb, where ratings are often the primary focus. However, this focus on Letterboxd delimits the thesis in several respects, as there is no cross-platform or cross-art form comparison.

While there is previous marketing research on movie reviewing, it has primarily focused on how online reviews affect box office outcomes, using quantified review data to predict revenues. Movie marketing studies have tried to explain either how expert reviews affect the decision to see motion pictures in movie theatres (e.g., Thrane, 2018) or more generally how the movie box office performance is correlated with online user scores (e.g., Chintagunta et al., 2010). These results provide an understanding as to why movie reviews are an important component of digital marketing (Moon et al., 2010). However, the conducted research has positioned movie reviews as outcomes/predictors, meaning that reviews are aggregated into data points, which are counted, averaged, and correlated with financial performance. This focus has left the reviewing process itself unexplored with no discernible marketing research on the transformational effects of reviewing on movie consumers themselves. This reveals a qualitative research gap of the existing marketing research, leaving the question "What are the effects of reviewing on the movie consumption experience itself?" unanswered.

The aforementioned research gap is significant for two reasons. First, it remains unclear what features consumers are considering during evaluation and how overall evaluative judgments are formed (Schneider et al., 2021). As Schneider et. al (2021) have already established, it is the considered features, and how consumers process those features, that substantially affect evaluative outcomes. This is especially evident on online movie reviewing platforms (e.g., Letterboxd, iMDb), where consumer reviews are often highly polarized (Nishijima et al., 2022). Secondly, by focusing only on the financial implications of movie reviewing, a crucial part of the consumption "backstory" is neglected. Therefore, to bridge this research gap, this thesis situates the interpretive/evaluative processes of online movie reviewing as a constitutive part of consumer culture, and examines the intricacies of art evaluations.

This thesis aims to reorient the extensive research on art marketing and revenue generation, by reorienting our research focus towards the review process itself. By collecting empirical material in the form of Letterboxd user reviews and interviews, we aim to answer how the act of reviewing transforms the reviewer's movie consumption experience. The central research question, based on the aims of this thesis, is as follows:

How does the practice of online reviewing affect movie consumption experiences?

By answering the research question, we aim to contribute to the practice of art marketing and the connected research streams. We attempt to reorient focus from financial outcomes to experiential outcomes in efforts to provide understanding of contemporary art consumption. Further

understanding the relation of online reviewing to art consumption experiences is also practically relevant to online review platforms, marketers, and cultural institutions.

CCT as a Guiding Theoretical Framework for Movie Reviewing

This theoretical chapter explains how the process of reviewing a movie is inherently tied with CCT. While Practice Theory seems like an obvious fit for studying the practice of movie reviewing, we instead use CCT as our macro-level theoretical basis. CCT is best suited since we study the transformational effects of reviewing and not routinized doings, materials, and competences that constitute Practice Theory (Warde, 2005). Thompson (2024, p. 555) articulates that CCT provides an “ontological bridge” which is necessary to bridge the gap between psychological decision making processes and consumers’ co-constituting relations to the socio-material world. Hence, this thesis combines CCT with theories from psychology research on evaluation (described further in the following APE model chapter) to enable our analysis on how reviewing practices affect movie consumption experiences.

Why CCT Is Relevant to Studying Movie Reviewing

The application of CCT perspectives to movie reviewing enables this thesis to study how consumers construct identities, negotiate meanings, and participate in a consumption community. It is important to clarify that CCT does not refer to one specific theory but rather to "a heteroglossic (cf. Bakhtin, 1981), and a conceptually dynamic field of inquiry that encompasses a multiplicity of theoretical approaches, methodological orientations, representational practices, and which speaks to a range of stakeholders" (Arnould & Thompson, 2015, p. 4). Nevertheless, at the core of CCT is the relationships “between lived culture and social resources,” which “are mediated through markets" (Arnould & Thompson, 2015, p. 14). This makes CCT particularly applicable for this study because it allows us to view movie consumption not as a singular, individual act of purchase or evaluation, but as a part of a culturally situated process of meaning-making (Belk, 1987; Holbrook & Hirschman, 1982).

CCT’s Distributed View of Cultural Meaning

CCT views culture as a non-homogenous entity, which Hannerz (1993, p. 16) calls a "distributed view of cultural meaning." Instead of viewing culture as one system of shared meanings and values, CCT explores how market-capitalism induced global socio-historical factors create consumer meanings (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). CCT emphasizes on the hybridization of consumption traditions and ways of life (Firat & Venkatesh, 1995). Although a distributive view of culture is not unique only to CCT, this stream of marketing research is helpful for

understanding how consumer culture is created. Consumer culture is situated in specific marketplace systems, and is being constantly shaped by cultural narratives (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). For this thesis, a distributed view of cultural meaning necessarily constitutes that there is no homogenous culture of movie reviewers. Therefore, only overlapping cultural groupings can be observed (e.g., fans of particular genres, directors, or eras), each of which are filled with unique meanings and practices.

CCT Conceptualizing Culture as the Fabric of Experience

CCT researchers view culture as the very basis of consumer experiences, and hence also meaning, and action. Consumer culture is a framework, which constitutes consumers' options of conceivable action, feeling, and thought, wherein certain patterns of behavior and sense-making are likelier than others (Schmitt et al., 2022). In the case of movie reviewing, this means that a specific platform (Letterboxd), and its specific parameters, frame what kinds of responses are conceivable and valued. CCT positions movie consumers/reviewers as continuous “learners,” constantly evaluating what counts as a "good" review. Reviewing practices are hence linked with existing cultural norms, which may also be innovated upon or resisted entirely by art consumers.

CCT Framing the Marketplace as a Cultural Resource

Another key premise of CCT is that consumers use the marketplace as a source of symbolic resources through which narratives of identity are constructed (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). Consumers are "identity seekers and makers," (Arnould & Thompson, 2005, p. 871) who are actively looking for personally meaningful symbols embedded within the marketplace to realize self-identity. Consuming movies, the practice of reviewing and the online reviewing platform itself are forms of symbolic resources, which make up the “diversified array of resources” (Arnould & Thompson, 2015, p. 6) consumers can use to perform identities. Online movie reviewers are also identity seekers, as well as meaning makers, who construct and perform their (movie) consumer identities.

The Research Programs within CCT and Their Relation to Art Reviewing

This thesis focuses specifically on the following three research programs within CCT: Consumer Identity Projects, Marketplace Cultures and Consumer Ideology.

Consumer Identity Projects

Of the four interrelated research domains existing within CCT research, three are of particular relevance to this study, the first of which is Consumer Identity Projects. As the name suggests, studies of Consumer Identity Projects investigate consumers’ sense of selves, or more specifically, how the co-constitutive/co-productive ways of consumers, together with marketer-generated materials, forge identities (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). Consumer identity

projects are most commonly considered to be goal-driven, but are often not clearly stated. Hence, consumer goals are not inherently coherent as they can be filled with internal contradictions (Arnould & Thompson, 2005).

This stream of research aligns with this thesis' intent to examine how online reviewers construct and perform identities through reviewing. As Schau & Gilly (2003) demonstrated in their study about personal websites, consumers use commercial symbols to create digital self-representations. Online movie reviewers also craft *reviewer* identities through their choices of films, personal rating systems, and what they write. An online movie review can then be considered "a blank canvas" for identity performance.

Marketplace Cultures

Another research stream of CCT is Marketplace Cultures, which studies how the rise of consumer culture constitutes how consumers act and interpret, and how each individual consumer contributes to the larger marketplace culture (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). Consumers are considered culture producers, which is in contrast with the traditional anthropological view of people as culture bearers (Thompson, 2024). Marketplace Cultures researchers further examine how the pursuit of common consumption interests shapes a sense of social unity and how consumers create consumption worlds, which are "distinctive, fragmentary, self-selected, and sometimes transient" (Arnould & Thompson, 2005, p. 873).

An online review platform (such as Letterboxd) can be conceived of as a *consumption world* (Holt, 1995), a social space organized around consumers' shared interest in movies and critique. More recent CCT scholarship has extended this concept by examining how consumers in collaborative networks actively co-create the rules of exchange, often producing *hybrid economies* that blend market and non-market logics (Scaraboto, 2015). In the context of Letterboxd, reviewers participate in a similar hybrid economy, as they produce content (reviews) for free, while the platform commercializes their aggregated activity. In the marketplace culture of Letterboxd, consumers participate in the ritual of logging and reviewing, which cultivates the consumer culture of "shared beliefs, meanings, mythologies, rituals, social practices, and status systems" (Arnould & Thompson, 2005, p. 874).

Consumer Ideology

The last relevant research program examines Consumer Ideology, which is conceived of as the systematic set of beliefs that (re)produce consumers' thoughts and actions in accordance with consumerism (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). Consumer Ideology focuses on how consumers make sense and respond to the normative messages produced by commercial media. Ritson & Elliott's (1999) research on the perception of advertisements showed that when consumers critique advertisements in a social context, they are collectively (re-)interpreting the message of a campaign. In the study of *consumption ideology,* consumers are positioned as interpretive agents,

who engage in meaning-creation activities (Schmitt et al., 2022). The existence of a consumption ideology is in a way inescapable, as individual interpretive strategies permeate every phase of the consumer journey, as well as social reality itself (Kozinets, 2002; Schmitt et al., 2022; Žižek, 1997).

The consumption ideology behind movie experiences is then quite relevant to understanding how online movie reviewers engage with both films and the social reality they find themselves in (Žižek, 1997). To simplify consumer ideology, Schmitt et al., (2022, p. 62) propose a 2×2 matrix of consumption orientations. Reconnection is a conformist mental stance embracing consumerist ideology; alienation is a resistive, anti-ideology mental stance; engagement is conformist communicative action; and activism is resistive communicative action opposing mainstream consumerist ideology. Hence, we can examine whether similar consumption orientations apply to online movie reviews, wherein Letterboxd users are collectively interpreting, critiquing, and reworking the meanings of films.

Studying Movie Reviewing From CCT Perspectives

The synthesization of CCT research streams allows this study to conceptualize movie reviewing on Letterboxd as a multifaceted cultural phenomenon. From the perspective of Consumer Identity Projects, reviewing is a practice through which users construct and perform “cinephile” identities. From the perspective of Marketplace Cultures, Letterboxd is a "consumption world," organized around shared interests, rituals and status systems, wherein users participate in collective meaning-making through their engagement with the platform and each other. From the perspective of Consumer Ideologies, reviewers collectively employ interpretive strategies to create a consensus of opinion.

These CCT perspectives provide this thesis a framework that positions online movie reviewing as a practice, which is inherently influenced by consumer culture. For this study, CCT is the fundamental theoretical basis for investigating how online movie reviews assist consumers in constructing identities, forging a sense of community, negotiating social structures, and engaging with ideological meanings. This macro-level theoretical framework of CCT complements the micro-level psychological processes described in the following chapter about the APE model. Ultimately, CCT perspectives enable us to conduct a multi-level (macro/micro) analysis on how the process of reviewing transforms movie consumption experience.

Mapping Movie Evaluations With The APE Model

While CCT provides this thesis a macro-level understanding of reviewing as part of consumer culture, CCT does not elaborate on the psychological processes underlying individual consumer evaluations. To address this, we introduce Gawronski & Bodenhausen’s (2006) Associative-Propositional Evaluation (APE) model, which enables us to conceptualize how

movie evaluative judgments are formed through the interaction of two distinct mental processes (associative/propositional). By focusing in on both a macro-cultural and micro-psychological level, we try to avoid what Thompson (2024, p. 562) refers to as *cherry picking* concepts from CCT "as mere grist for the theory testing mill." The APE model is used for theorizing the unobservable processes that generate observable reviews, which is crucial since it is only possible to "observe the outcome but not the process" (Schneider et al. 2021, p. 585).

Associative vs. Propositional Processes

At the core of the APE model is the mental distinction between *associative processes* and *propositional processes* (Gawronski & Bodenhausen, 2006). These processes form two distinct types of evaluations, which Gawronski & Bodenhausen (2006) refer to as implicit and explicit attitudes. In the case of movie evaluations, involuntary affective reactions are a part of the implicit attitudes, and deliberative articulated judgments are the explicit attitudes (Schneider et al., 2021). This distinction is necessary for initially differentiating and, later on, analyzing the evaluations expressed by the Letterboxd reviewers.

Associative Processes as The Basis of Implicit Evaluation

Associative evaluations are characterized by Gawronski & Bodenhausen (2006, p. 693) as "automatic affective reactions resulting from the particular associations that are activated automatically when one encounters a relevant stimulus." The words "activated automatically" are important here, since this means that associative evaluations do not require cognitive awareness – there is no perceived intention by the consumer to evaluate an object (Cunningham et al., 2004). Therefore, implicit film evaluations occur when certain associations activate unconsciously (Schneider et al., 2021). For example, prior knowledge of a director's cinematic style might evoke certain associations/expectations, whilst such activations occur implicitly. without conscious effort or deliberate control.

Importantly, associative processes are independent from an individual's cognitive perception of what is *actually* true. Associative evaluations can happen unconsciously, and are not dependent on whether an individual considers them accurate or not (Gawronski & Bodenhausen, 2006). This understanding is key for distinguishing associative processing from propositional reasoning in the context of movie reviewing. Continuing with the example of a reviewer being familiar with a director's work, previous disappointing experiences can automatically elicit negative affective reactions. Similar associations, regardless if positive or negative in nature, activate automatically, regardless of their perceived validity and/or a conscious recognition of an inherent bias (Schneider et al., 2021).

The activation of thought patterns are also central to associative processes (Smith, 1996). Essentially, the creation of an associative evaluation is based on the fit between a set of external

input stimuli and the preexisting associations in memory (Schneider et al., 2021). It is then also the *in vitro* context wherein the experience happens which determines the recruited associative patterns (Smith, 1996). The process of evaluating movies might bring forth different associations when viewed in different contexts (e.g., at a cinema vs. at home), or, more pertinently, when interacting with an online review platform. The online consumer review platform is then itself a part of the input stimuli that activates pattern recognition, as well as the remembered associations.

For the specific platform context of this thesis (Letterboxd), associative processes take form in the emotional, intuitive elements hidden within the act of reviewing. Reviews which express visceral reactions (e.g., this LoTR review on Letterboxd: “frodo 🥺 wouldn’t 🥺 have 🥺 got 🥺 far 🥺 without 🥺 sam 🥺”*)* may show emotions which have not been subjected to deliberative reflection. These emotionally *raw* evaluations can be conceived of as an expression of automatic affective reactions, stemming from associative processes. When gathering empirical materials about the practice of online movie reviewing, implicit evaluations need to be mapped alongside the explicit evaluations described in the following chapter.

Propositional Processes as The Basis of Explicit Evaluation

Propositional processes differ from associative processes, since propositional processes are concerned with the validation of evaluations and beliefs. The explicit, observable evaluations resulting from propositional processes, are more akin to “evaluative judgments that are based on syllogistic inferences derived from any kind of propositional information that is considered relevant for a given judgment" (Gawronski and Bodenhausen, 2006, p. 694). This means that a process of deductive reasoning is necessary to reach explicit evaluations, wherein two premises are used to arrive at a necessary conclusion. Simply put, a (re)viewer must construct a subjective line of reasoning for expressing their explicit evaluation (e.g., answering the question “Why do I think this movie is good/bad?”).

In the APE model, propositional reasoning functions are based on associative inputs that have been modified to fit into a propositional format (Schneider et al., 2021). Following this logic, a negative affective reaction is transformed into the proposition: "I dislike X," and becomes subject to deductive logical arguments that assess its validity. For instance, the affective response of “I love this movie” is either justified with a reason (e.g., “because the acting is great”) or overruled (e.g., “I actually only love the actor, not the movie”).

The distinctive feature of propositional processes is their dependency on truth values. Whereas associative activations occur independently of perceived truth or falsity, propositional reasoning is concerned with validation (Gawronski & Bodenhausen, 2006). Propositional processes culminate with the answer to the question: “Is this evaluation valid?” Often by default, propositional reasoning affirms the validity of their automatic affective reactions (Gilbert, 1991).

In such cases, an affective reaction ("I dislike X") is the entire basis of the evaluative judgment. In other cases, when an automatic affective reaction is rejected as invalid, evaluative judgments are independent; unaffected by feelings of affection.

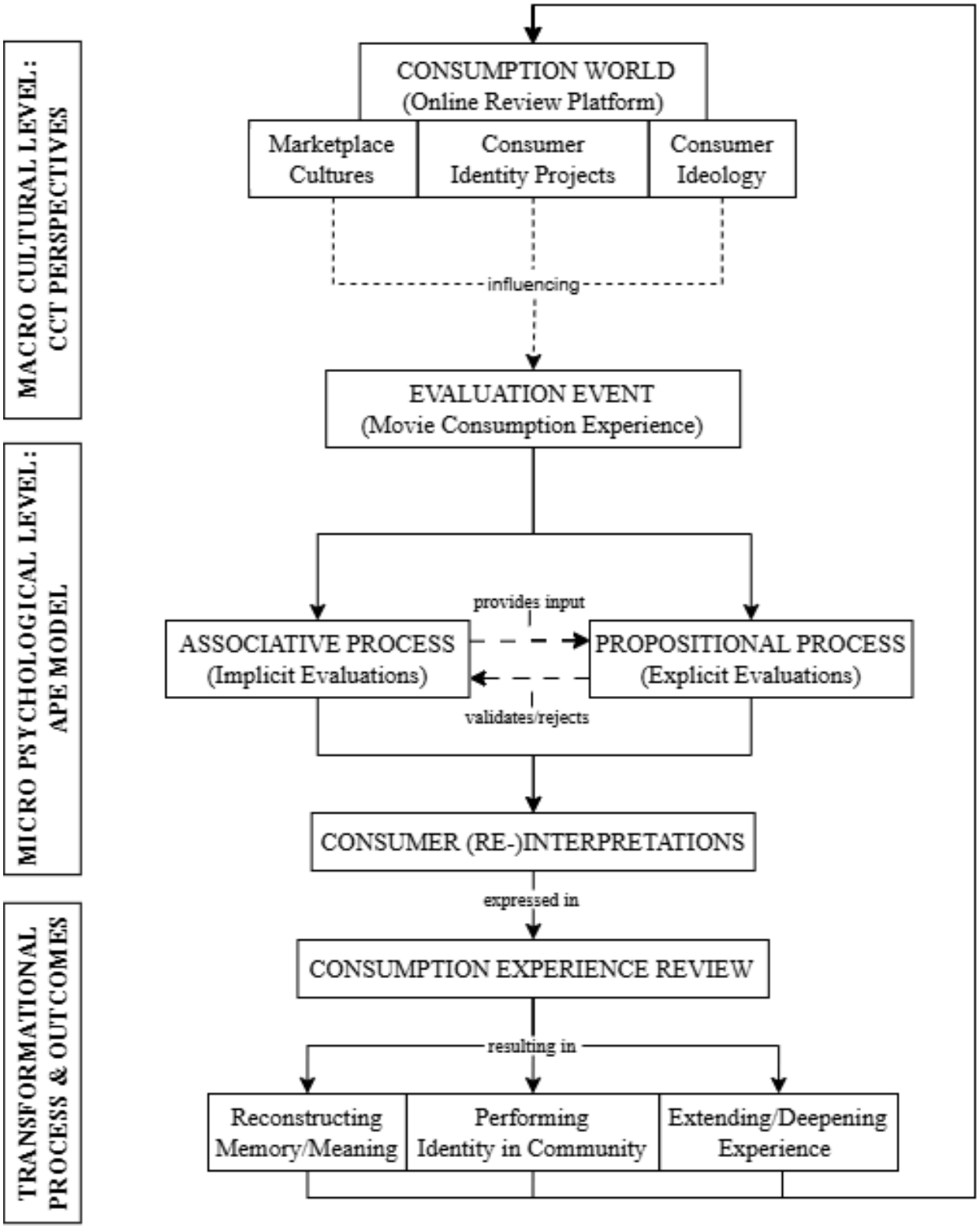
The perceived validity of an evaluation also depends on consistency, or rather on whether the other relevant propositions are in alignment (Schneider et al., 2021). In the case of movie evaluations, a (re)viewer may have an automatic negative affective reaction to a film featuring a perceivably “pretentious” or a “bad” director. However, this reaction may be inconsistent with other propositions they hold. For instance, they might have been affected by the external validation a film received, such as the film was “good enough” to win an Oscar or has high praise within the Letterboxd community. Inconsistencies among propositions can result in the rejection of the affective reaction as an invalid basis for judgment, resulting in a different explicit evaluation than their implicit reaction would predict (Schneider et al., 2021). Alternatively, a (re)viewer can also find an additional proposition that resolves the inconsistency (e.g., "This director has actually improved significantly over time"). The additional proposition confirms the negative affective reaction as valid, which leads to alignment between the implicit and explicit evaluation.

In the context of CCT, explicit movie evaluations are affected by the “consumption world,” and are displayed in review texts through the result of propositional reasoning processes. More specifically, propositional processes are the analytical, reflective, and argumentative elements embedded within the review process. Propositional reasoning provides agency to movie (re)viewers to either validate or reject their initial affective reactions against other relevant propositions, according to their own volition.

A Multi-Level Model of Movie Reviewing

Figure 1 presents a conceptual model of reviewing as a transformative consumption practice. The diagram integrates the macro-level cultural dynamics extrapolated from CCT with the micro-level psychological processes of the APE model. Figure 1 is a visual representation of the empirical investigation that follows, specifically the transformational outcomes that come forth

Figure 1. *A Multi-Level Model of the Practice of Online Movie Reviewing, Incorporating CCT (Arnould & Thompson, 2005) with The APE Model (Gawronski & Bodenhausen, 2006*)



from the act of reviewing. The diagram is structured in three tiers, moving from the cultural context to individual cognitive processing and finally to the transformative outcomes that feed back into the cultural context. The level of analysis of this thesis focuses both on the micro-level individual reviews and the macro-level cultural view, since each reviewer is one cog in the consumption world of online movie reviewing.

Macro Cultural Level: CCT Perspectives

At the top of the model, the macro cultural level captures the broader sociocultural environment in which art reviewing takes place. Central to this level is the consumption world (Holt, 1995) of the online review platform, containing interrelated CCT research programs. Consumer evaluations operate as the mediating link between the macro- and micro-level context, since the consumption world is simultaneously shaped by and shaping the consumers that are engaged in it. Therefore, the presented model (Figure 1) is circular, meaning that the individual transformational outcomes continuously and collectively affect the consumption world.

Micro-Level Psychological Processes: The APE Model

The middle section of the diagram operationalises the internal processes that convert a consumption experience into an evaluative judgment. Following Gawronski & Bodenhausen's (2006) APE model, two distinct but interacting systems are distinguished as associative processes and propositional processes. First, implicit evaluations occur without conscious deliberation and then feed explicit evaluations, which deliberately validate the outputs of associative processing with reasoning and previous understandings. The reviewer engages in deductive reasoning, asking whether initial reactions are justified, consistent with other beliefs, or aligned with external sources. Through this process, the reviewer may either affirm the initial reaction or override it, arriving at an explicit evaluative judgment.

In the diagram (Figure 1), bidirectional arrows between propositional and associative processes show that associative inputs can initiate propositional reasoning, and repeated explicit judgments can be automated and affect associative processes. This interaction provides understanding as to how reviewing practices may change over time and how the reviewer "matures".

The output of the propositional process is a set of consumer (re-)interpretations: the "justified" reasonings, and personal meanings that the consumer has constructed, representing a (re-)construction of the experience. As previously noted, active evaluation (a review) forces the consumer to move from a passive state into active sense-making, thereby solidifying and sometimes altering the initial impression.

The Transformational Outcomes of Movie Reviewing

When movie consumers engage in the review process, it is possible to see their (re-)interpretations of evaluations and how reviewing can transform a movie consumption experience. Based on the reviewed literature, we posit three following transformational outcomes of movie reviewing that alter the consumption experience itself:

Deepening Consumption Experiences: Reviewing requires reflection and articulation (described by Schneider et al., 2021 as propositional reasoning), which prolongs engagement with the experience. The development of propositional reasoning through reviewing is then how movie reviewers transform their consumption experience.

(Re-)Constructing Consumption Memories & Meanings: While not directly addressed in either the APE model or CCT, autobiographical memory theory is also an essential part of consumer evaluations. Tulving (2002) has discussed how past consumption experiences are stored as episodic traces that are reconstructed each time they are retrieved. This line of research was further developed by Moliner-Tena et al., (2023), who explain that episodic/autobiographical memory is "a subsystem of Long Term Memory (LTM) where associations of an autobiographical event relating to time, space, emotions or other contextual circumstances are stored" (pg. 2). From this line of psychological research, a written online review is one part of the constant construction of LTM, which anchors explicit evaluations in-time.

Furthermore, psychological researchers use the term *memory phenomenology* (Moliner-Tena et al., 2023) to describe the subjective experience of reliving an experience. As was also partly covered by Schneider et al. (2021), two dimensions of memory phenomenology are especially relevant to movie evaluation/reviewing. *Vividness* of a memory reflects the ability to recall details of specific consumption experiences. (Cooper et al., 2019). *Sharing* considers whether and how the experience was shared with other people (Sutin & Robins, 2007). Reviewing can elicit *vividness,* as reviewers are prompted to recall their experience, but when combined with an online platform they are also *sharing* it. Moliner-Tena et al. (2023, p. 3) say that *sharing*, "enables greater social integration and […] activates the sharing dimension" of autobiographical memory. Also we must not forget to mention the forgetting theory, which states that memories *decay* over time or become harder to retrieve because other memories induce *interference* (Jonides et al., 2008).

Exceptionally vivid recollections of surprising or significant experiences are known as *flashbulb events*, which can be defined as "an extreme case of the memory of an event, which take the shape of extremely vivid, detailed and emotional memories" (Moliner-Tena et al., 2023, p. 2). Developing a system of propositional reasoning can make reviews function as a *flashbulb event* like memory by adding layers of personal significance to prior experiences (Schneider et al., 2021).

Ultimately this transformational outcome posits that a review is a shared, vivid reconstruction of a consumption experience. This aligns with Moliner-Tena et al.'s (2023) broader claim about how a memory theory perspective enables a connection between human memory theory and service-dominant logic. The review process enables consumers to engage in active meaning-making, allowing for them to encapsulate and remember personal consumption memories.

Performance of Identity in a Consumer Community: Online reviews are shared in certain consumer communities (e.g., Letterboxd), and are therefore inherently social performances. The awareness of the "audience" shapes reviews and turns the expression of a consumption experience into an opportunity for expressing Consumer Ideologies and a sense of one's identity in relation to other consumption world members.

The Cycle of Consumption

The presented model (Figure 1) implies a cyclical dynamic. Online reviews lead back into the CCT macro-level: becoming a part of the consumption world discourse, influencing consumption norms, and shaping the content that other community members encounter. The micro level is also affected, since past review experiences influence both associative and propositional processes. The cyclical view is in alignment with the thesis's central premise that an art consumption experience is not only the viewing experience, but instead a co-creative process, happening ongoingly through interactions with art and within the consumption world.

How to Review Reviews: Research Design

To investigate how the practice of online reviewing transforms movie consumption experiences, this study first uses netnography: a qualitative research method adapted from ethnography to study online communities (Kozinets, 2002). Netnography is particularly suited to our research aim because it provides a window into naturally occurring, unsolicited consumer behaviors that are not fabricated by the researcher. Netnography allows for the unobtrusive observation of consumers engaging in communal meaning-making within their native digital environment, offering access to the symbolism, linguistic conventions, and consumption patterns of online consumer groups (Kozinets, 2002). For this thesis, netnography enabled us to collect and interpret Letterboxd user reviews as cultural performances embedded within a consumption world (Kozinets, 2002).

The research is structured as a two-phase, iterative study, combining netnography with semi-structured interviews. The dual-method approach allows for more context about users themselves and their reviews, as we are able to first familiarize ourselves with user reviews and

then follow up with interviews for more in-depth, self-reflective insights. This enables us to better understand the motivations and introspections underlying users' public reviews.

Recruitment of Interview Participants

Recruiting participants directly through Letterboxd was challenging due to the platform's structural limitations. Unlike any other social media, Letterboxd does not offer the option of direct messaging or any chat feature. If users did not include external contact information such as email addresses or social media handles, it was impossible to reach out to them. This made it difficult to target individual users directly on the platform without leaving public comments on their reviews. This approach felt intrusive and unlikely to lead to any meaningful responses.

We chose TikTok as an alternative channel to recruit potential interviewees. mostly because of its active cinephile communities. We used hashtags while conducting research which included: #letterboxd, #moviereview, #filmtok, #cinemalover over a four-week period in April 2026. Public videos with content regarding movies and Letterboxd reviewing on that platform were used to screen for relevance. Furthermore, potential candidates were contacted through TikTok direct messages with a brief invitation to the study. In total around 200 people were contacted which resulted in 13 interviews. No incentives were offered.

Participant Diversity

The final sample of 13 participants was intentionally diverse in terms of nationality, reviewing background and also engagement on the platform. Participants were from nine different countries: the United Kingdom, the United States, Spain, France, Germany, Sweden, Poland, Venezuela and Estonia. The variety of nationalities have provided a broad range of different cultural perspectives on online film reviewing and movie consumption.

On top of that the sample included participants with different approaches to the reviewing experience and online presence. Some of the interviewees belonged to the group of large creators with a significant amount of followers on platforms like TikTok and Letterboxd. They regularly received press invitations to attend premiere screenings and collaborated with film distribution. Furthermore, we collaborated with smaller creators with lesser following on Letterboxd who reviewed for small-scale community engagement or their own satisfaction. Others could be named as lone archivists whose relation with Letterboxd is more private, as they used Letterboxd primarily as a logging tool, with little to no interest in social engagement on the platform. The study also included professional or semi-professional reviewers, often film students or video editors. Another group consisted of casual viewers who review sporadically when they feel like it and mostly for films that leave a strong emotional impact.

Some of the participants used Letterboxd as their main “movie” platform, while others used it in the meantime while relying more on TikTok or Youtube. Interviewees attitudes towards reviewing practice were diverse. Some of them were analytical and serious, whereas other users logged one-line or joke reviews. This heterogeneity was intentional, reflecting CCT’s “distributed view of cultural meaning” (Arnould & Thompson, 2005).

Interview Procedure

All of the interviews were conducted online between March and April 2026. To ensure interviewees comfort, we used a range of platforms to meet their preferred one, such as: Zoom, Microsoft Teams, Discord, Google Meet and FaceTime audio. In the end the specific platform was chosen by the participant. Each interview lasted from 30 to 80 minutes.

All interviews were audio-recorded with the usage of OBS (Open Broadcaster Software) and later transcribed using ElevenLabs, a professional transcription tool, and manually corrected with any errors.

The semi-structured interviews were guided by the open-ended questions, which allowed to better understand and explore reviewers perspectives. The complete interview guide is provided in the Appendix.

Data Collection and Coding

Table 1. *Interview Participants*

Letterboxd Username	**Date of First Review**	**Amount of Films Reviewed**
hermitmaxxr2000	13.03.2024	65
someone_272	20.04.2026	20
mvrtsysy	07.12.2024	13
Anonymous User 1	24.12.2022	30
joy_plague	18.04.2024	20
Anonymous User 2	02.12.2024	107
dila_ern	09.08.2024	58

heythisisjames	16.10.2019	5407
jophesface	24.10.2024	187
filmbecomesher_	22.10.2021	333
ngc__4486	05.10.2022	103
elementarii	07.01.2018	779
Anonymous User 3	08.12.2019	215

From the pool of identified users we selected reviews, which created a purposive sample of text-based reviews. Selection criteria was utilized to collect reviews, this includes layered emotional language, personal narratives or self-identity meaning-making. A target of 260 reviews was collected to strive for data saturation. All selected reviewers and reviews were copied into a safe database, along with the review texts. Relevant contextual data was recorded, including: the film reviewed, the user's star rating and the date of the review.

Following Braun & Clarke's (2006) six-phase thematic analysis, interview transcripts and review texts were imported into NVivo. Initial codes were generated inductively from the data, then organized deductively according to the APE model (associative/propositional) and the three transformational outcomes (deepening, memory reconstruction, identity performance). Codes were refined iteratively, with memos documenting analytical decisions.

Table 2. *Analysis codes*

Code Name	Definition	Example from Data
Associative evaluation	Immediate, affective, visceral reaction judgments without justification	"I like Brad Pitt and that's why I like that movie"
Associative processing	Description of how associations manifest	"My whole body reacts to it"
Propositional evaluation	Deliberate, reasoned judgments with justification	"The demon plot was lame because the execution failed"
propositional reasoning	Description of analytical thinking about films	"I need to gather information in my head to relive the

		movie"
Deepening of experience	How reviewing prolongs or intensifies engagement	"Writing gives me closure... catharsis"
Memory reconstruction	How reviewing creates or alters memory of the film	"I can always go back and see my state of mind"
Expression of identity	How reviews construct and perform cinephile self	"My fragile identity is tied to comedy"
Expression of culture	References to community, norms, platform discourse	"What was I going to say that hasn't been said?"

Trustworthiness

To ensure the trustworthiness of our thesis, we followed the framework proposed by Lincoln and Guba (operationalised by Shenton, 2004). We address four criteria: credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability.

Credibility

While we employed several strategies to ensure our findings credibility to represent a true picture of the phenomenon under scrutiny (Shenton, 2004), we must acknowledge a significant sampling bias. Reviewers and their reviews were intentionally selected for characteristics that align with the very phenomena we set out to study. This means our findings cannot be generalized to all Letterboxd reviewers, as we have heavily prioritized theory-building in our research design and not representativeness.

We combined netnographic analysis of 260 Letterboxd reviews with semi-structured interviews of 13 active users to compensate for the limitations of one singular research approach (Shenton, 2004). We tried to achieve data source triangulation by recruiting a diverse range of users (9 different countries, different reviewing habits). As we experienced difficulties in initially recruiting participants, our cohort of interview participants were skewed towards engaged users, who were willing to express themselves in a research context.

We also applied Shenton's (2004, p. 66) "tactics to help ensure honesty in informants." Participants were informed they could (1) withdraw from our thesis project at any point; (2) express themselves freely; (3) provide no "wrong answers" (Shenton, 2004).

“Peer scrutiny” (Shenton, 2004, p. 67) of the thesis project was achieved through regular discussions with our thesis supervisor Peter Zackariasson. We received feedback on our research progress and use of theory, which we used to strengthen our arguments and final text.

Peer scrutiny was accompanied by a reflective commentary throughout our research process. To record "progressive subjectivity" (Shenton, 2004, p. 68) we kept a track of emerging patterns in the data and our evolving interpretations.

Transferability

Since this thesis covers specifically movie reviewing on Letterboxd, the transferability of our findings to other situations have to be made clear (Shenton, 2004). Our qualitative findings are specific to the thesis’ research context: studied specifically the Letterboxd platform; used theories from CCT and APE-model, employed netnography and semi-structured interviews for research material collection; interviewed 13 active users of 9 different nationalities; analyzed 260 reviews; conducted research in April 2026. This “thick description” of our research context allows readers to assess the transferability of this thesis’ findings to other situations (Shenton, 2004, p. 69).

Dependability

To address the dependability of our thesis, we have reported our research processes in detail in our methodological chapter. This was done so future research can be conducted in a similar fashion in efforts to see if similar results would be obtained . This enables a future researcher to repeat the work, if not necessarily to obtain the same results (Shenton, 2004).

Confirmability

The confirmability of our research depends on the extent to which we were able to convey true experiences of our interview participants (Shenton, 2004). While we acknowledge our inherent investigator bias, we took several measures to promote confirmability. Triangulation was used to reduce the effect of investigator bias by incorporating multiple methods and data sources (Shenton, 2004). Our methodological decisions developed through scrutiny and open discussion with the thesis supervisor and we recorded our analysis progress throughout. As suggested by Shenton (2004), an audit trail documenting analytical decisions, coding iterations, and methodological choices has been maintained and is available upon request. Nevertheless, we acknowledge several limitations of our research, which we cover in detail in the Discussion chapter.

Ethical Considerations: A Good Research Practice

Throughout the entire research process, we prioritized ethical handling of data as a matter of professional responsibility and respect. The approach is rooted in the Good Research Practice framework, which serves as a detailed roadmap for addressing potential ethical issues. Principles of honesty, transparency, and the safeguarding of participant privacy are in accordance with the ethical foundation of Swedish research (Vetenskapsrådet, 2017).

Special attention was paid to the public-private distinction in online spaces, since this study employs netnography. Publicly accessible data does not automatically equate to an absence of privacy expectations; community members may regard ostensibly public environments as private (Paoli, 2025). With that in mind, we treated all user data with caution: usernames are only disclosed with explicit permission, and all identifying information from interviews was removed during transcription.

All data collection was conducted in accordance with GDPR requirements for student projects, which mandate that participation be voluntary, informed, and revocable, with consent documented prior to data collection (Göteborgs Universitet, 2024). Informed consent was obtained from all interview participants after providing a clear information sheet about the study's purpose and their rights. The research focus remained exclusively on participants' reviewing practices and experiences with the platform, rather than on personal biographical data. Finally, personal data will be deleted upon completion of the course and grade submission, in line with university guidelines for student theses.

Use of Generative AI

In line with the University of Gothenburg's guidelines on generative AI, we disclose the limited use of AI tools in this thesis (University of Gothenburg, 2025). ElevenLabs was used for initial interview transcription, but all transcripts were manually corrected against original audio. DeepSeek was used to review completed sections of our text and provide editing suggestions, such as identifying unclear phrasing, grammatical errors, and need to clarify our argumentation. All AI-generated suggestions were critically evaluated, and final decisions on all changes remained entirely ours. We did not use AI for research design, data collection, data analysis, theoretical development, or finding generation. The authors assume full responsibility for the originality and accuracy of all content.

Analysis

In the following analysis chapter, we cover how individual review practices relate to the proposed model in Figure 1, and what mechanisms related to online reviewing affect movie consumption experiences.

Theme 1: Reviewing Extends and Deepens the Consumption Experience

The first transformational outcome (described in Figure 1) posits that the act of reviewing prolongs engagement with the reviewed artwork and transforms a one-time experience into a process of meaning making. Our interview participants described how reviewing adds something to the consumption experience, which passive consumption lacks. The way in which the consumption experience was affected by reviewing varied across participants, which we categorized as affective prolongation or cognitive prolongation.

Associative Processes' Relation to Affective Prolongation

When participants were asked "what does reviewing mean to you," many described what we categorized as affective prolongation. Reviewing allowed immediate (associative) reactions to be processed and put into a personal context.

"When I review, I feel like I'm releasing those emotions… It feels like a closing chapter to having experienced some great art." - user mvrtsysy

A review of *Die My Love* (2025) exemplifies what we mean by affective prolongation. Immediately after watching, the reviewer "didn't feel anything," which we interpreted as an associative evaluation of numbness. Over several days, a "long deep feeling" developed, growing stronger until user mvrtsysy felt almost "compelled to write." The act of writing forced reflection and produced what the user describes as "catharsis" and "closure." Without the review, user mvrtsysy suggested that "emotional baggage" would remain unresolved.

"In the beginning, after just watching the movie, I didn't feel anything. But this feeling came up after like two days and only grew stronger and at one point it was so strong I felt like, 'Okay, I have to write a review to get rid of it [the feeling] and to deal with it.' " - user mvrtsysy

This example does not mean that articulated reviews always lead to further understanding, which some reviews showcased:

"This movie felt so genuine, I don't know how they did it…" - user mvrtsysy review of *Almost Famous* (2000)

Other participants also described the reviewing process through cathartic language, helping them deal with feelings that otherwise could remain internally unresolved. For some, articulating symbolism and personal connections to the artwork allowed them to externalize lingering feelings. User dila_ern explained that they often write reviews right after crying during a film, since the associative reaction compels them to engage in propositional reasoning.

"And when I, when there is a sign of me crying, I immediately put my thoughts because, like, why did I cry? Why was I so emotional?" - user dila_ern

In another example, dila_ern described being motivated to review a film through feelings of "female rage":

"It was, like, 3:00 AM in the morning and it really motivated me to put my thoughts into the review, and it was driven by my female rage, I would say, and how awful humanity can be, how cruel it can be." - user dila_ern

Since these emotions were so intense and difficult, reviewing became a medium to deal with them. Importantly, some reviews are to resolve the emotional reaction it produced. The reviewing/writing process became a way for participants to reflect on why certain emotions carried such intensity, where they originated from, and, at a core, what they revealed about themselves. While we cannot directly observe the automatic processing that is happening during the review process, participants' descriptions of visceral reactions provide indirect evidence of its role.

A reviewing practice can then be a vehicle for how consumers resolve and process emotions felt through movie consumption experiences. Associative movie evaluations (immediate, visceral reactions) can be overwhelming, and the emotional weight from the movie consumption experience can last for a longer period of time. Engaging with the review process is then how the automatic processing of associative evaluations is being subconsciously developed, and how future associative evaluations are manifested.

Propositional Reasoning's Relation to Cognitive Prolongation

The deepening effect of reviewing can also be primarily cognitive, differing from the affective prolongation. Unlike reviewers who write to vent or to analyze, a reviewing practice can in some cases resemble more of a film celebration, where it builds up on emotional energy.

"When I come out of a film and I've just thoroughly enjoyed it and I'm writing a review about how much I loved it, it definitely does intensify. It's just like a love letter to the film. It does make me feel a more intense feeling toward the film." – user jophesface

What makes this finding interesting is that, for some, reviewing changes opinions on the film for the better.

“Upon rewatch, when I was writing my second review, I was realizing how great it is and how much I just love all the decisions in the film. It definitely did make me realize I enjoyed it a lot more than my initial thoughts.” - user jophesface

Here reviewing constructs an enhanced reimagination of a movie, as writing about enjoyment can generate more enjoyment, leading to more enthusiasm about reviewing practice and movie consumption.

For others, a reviewing practice was a method for achieving a sense of critical understanding of the movie consumption experience.

“Usually, it turns out that I like movies less ... because I tend to overanalyze.” - anonymous user

A retelling of a review of the movie *Sinister* (2012), illustrates this aspect. While initially captivated by the premise (an associative evaluation), a written analysis concluded that “the demon plot was lame” and the overall execution flawed. Here, the deepened engagement produced critical disappointment instead of “catharsis” or “positive valence.” This is relevant to the covered CCT theory, because the valence of prolongation (how consumption experience is perceived as more or less positive) depended on the reviewer's lived experience. Relating this to the APE model, we see how the developing propositional reasoning system either overrides positive associative reactions, or affirms and deepens them.

A continuous reviewing practice can also develop a sense of personal cinematic quality over time.

“Before starting reviewing, I had a bunch of movies that were four plus stars ... But after starting to review, I have realized quite some shortcomings.” - user hermitmaxxr2000

Here engaging in the reviewing process directly shapes future viewing experience, wherein:

“The reviewing process just doesn't start when the movie ends ... by the time the movie ends, I already kind of know what I want to review, what I liked and what I disliked.” - user hermitmaxxr2000

For some reviewers, the anticipated act of writing creates a continuous feedback loop between watching and evaluating. The reviewer becomes a more attentive viewer, since they have previously developed their propositional reasoning capabilities through reviewing.

User heythisisjames described a similar occurrence, but from a social angle. When they started reviewing films, they paid attention to what others would think of their reviews. Over time, they learned to ignore any pressure that might have been caused by people and started to rely more on their own reasoning.

“I certainly did think about, 'What will people think about this?' when I started. And then I think I didn't learn how to let that go until maybe a year into doing TikTok.” - user heythisisjames

This implies that the development of propositional reasoning from a reviewing practice is not only personal but also social. Reviewers learn to validate their own judgments against the imagined audience’s potential criticism.

Self-awareness can also align with the development of propositional reasoning:

“I'll always come up with a number after a film for the star rating. But then when I'm actually laying out my opinions, I'm sort of like, 'Oh, yeah, I actually thought this…' Like, when the stuff I'm saying, it doesn't actually sound that good. I do think the ones where I write a longer review are more informed.” - user jophesface

Initial star ratings can often be misleading, and engaging in the review practice produces a “more informed” judgment. This is directly associated with how propositional reasoning can override initial associative evaluations.

How Online Reviewing Prolongs Engagement with Movie Consumption Experiences

All participants exhibited some form of prolonged engagement from an active practice of reviewing. This does not mean that there is a uniform deepening of experience, as reviewers have different meanings for their personal movie reviewing practice. This finding is then in line with CCT’s central premise of “the distributed view of cultural meaning” (Arnould & Thompson, 2005).

Central to this theme is how future reviews were affected by the gained reviewing experience. In some cases, the maturing of the reviewer’s reviewing process evoked better understanding of associative evaluations and the development of propositional reasoning capabilities. In regards to the multi-level model proposed in Figure 1, the movie consumer/reviewer identity is in a constant state of evolution. Through each articulation of movie consumption experiences, consumers create their identity project, develop their evaluative disposition, and their co-creative relations to the consumption world they are situated within.

Theme 2: Reviewing Reconstructs Memory and Meaning

The next analysis theme draws from memory reconstruction theory (Jonas et al., 2023; Moliner-Tena et al., 2023). Our findings showed how reviewers instill self-identity within some reviews, and how movie reviewing can overwrite or solidify the memory of a consumption experience. This was expressed by the interview participants in 3 ways: rewriting significance, temporal anchoring, and humorous encoding.

The Significance of Rewriting

One user's experience with the film *Stoker* (2013) was an especially vivid example of reviewing impacting the personal significance of a film. User mvrtsysy watched the movie with no expectations, enjoyed it, but did not consider it to be "relevant." A realization of a deep connection with the film occurred after engaging with the review process:

"Even after watching it… I was like, 'this is still not the most relevant movie.' But after I wrote a review, I realized I actually connect more to it than I thought." - user mvrtsysy

We found other examples of similar experiences, wherein a reviewing practice is the core part of movie consumption experiences. User heythisisjames described how reviewing could alter the intensity and direction of their feelings toward a movie: "in reflection, it can sometimes be quite different or even greater or lesser." Rather than only documenting reactions formed during viewing, the writing process influences the interpretation and evaluation of the film, sometimes helping them realize how they actually felt about the experience. However, the direction and magnitude of this intensification differed between users and situations. In user heythisisjames' case, it moved toward a more negative direction. Reflecting on the film, they realized that they "actually don't have really anything positive to say," eventually concluding that "that's when the clarity kind of kicks in" that they "did not like this film or this experience." This finding further emphasizes the importance of the APE model when it comes to the consumer-centric view on the impacts of online movie reviewing. Reviewing forces propositional reasoning, which in turn validates/rejects associative evaluations, and develops the self-identity of the movie consumer.

A contrary finding to what we assumed based on consumer memory literature is how the actual movie consumption experience can be overshadowed by the review itself.

"I wrote a review, and I think that review shaped me more than the movie I think. I can't recall the review, but it gave me this feeling." - user dila_ern

This example shows how highly dedicated reviewers can focus on the creative outlet the reviewing process provides, which then becomes more significant than watching the movie. Memory decay after reviewing still occurs, possibly because other reviewing related memories induce interference (Moliner-Tena et al., 2023). The memory of the review is then more substantial than the consumption experience itself and the meaning of the consumption experience comes more from the review than the actual movie.

We did see support for the idea that reviews rewrite the film's significance retroactively, which is consistent with the APE model's propositional override: associative inputs can be rejected as invalid, and a new explicit judgment constructed through reasoning (Schneider et al., 2021). The review becomes the official evaluation of the experience, which can be recalled in the future. For example, another review of the movie *Die My Love* (2025) transformed "an initial sense of

irrelevance" into a "devastatingly accurate" portrayal of mental illness. As was the case with other users, the review process constructs a response that is more articulate, more meaningful, and more memorable than the initial, *raw* experience itself.

Temporal Anchoring

Reviewing also places films to the reviewer's personal timeline, which is inherently related to the concept of episodic traces from autobiographical memory theory (Tulving, 2002).

"I check my timeline… I see in what months I saw what kind of movies. And then I sometimes relive those months and that time in my head again." - user hermitmaxxr2000

Through coding, we identified a pattern of reviews as temporal anchors, akin to fixed episodic traces, which allow for the navigation of past consumption experiences. Reviewed movies are remembered for their content, as well as, for the life context in which they are experienced. In contrast, unreviewed movies are not shared nor vividly expressed through a review, and are susceptible to memory decay:

"There's so many movies, like maybe even thousands of movies that I've watched, and I just don't remember them because I never thought about them more." - anonymous user

Furthermore, we observed that writing a review forced a deliberate, effortful retrieval of a memory, strengthening episodic traces as temporal anchors. This can make it less vulnerable to memory decay and interference, as was expressed clearly by one of our interviewees:

"If I leave a review, I'm going to mentally enforce and solidify that criticism... even when years go by, I know where it landed, like, was it four stars, three stars, then I automatically know, like, oh, okay, it maybe was an okay movie." - user hermitmaxxr2000

Even just a star rating itself can become a temporal anchor that solidifies the evaluative assessment of experience. This suggests that the quantified aspect of reviewing (star ratings) does not only serve an aggregative function but also as a mnemonic device for the reviewer.

"When I come back to a review from years ago, I can see my thoughts and be like, 'Oh, I still agree with myself,' or 'Oh, I changed my mind.' It's nice in retrospect to see the list of movies you've reviewed and being like, 'Oh, I remember this.'" - user heythisisjames

A recorded review makes a movie consumption revisitable, as past identities can be felt again when re-reading past reviews. This has the ability to prevent memory decay and aligns with the APE model's propositional reasoning, since writing forces the reviewer to validate/reject associative evaluations. Previous reviews can be perceived as a mirror, where a reviewer can check what they thought about a movie but also who they were as a person at a certain time of

his life. This occurrence links to Consumer Identity Projects, where the review becomes a recorded file of the one's evolving self-identity.

"If I write a review, it's in my daily life like that. If I experience something really important or really life-changing, I have a lot of thoughts and feelings, and I typically write them down, and then they are, like, anchored on a page and I can look back with the feelings just running over me." - user dila_ern

Humorous Encoding

Other reviewers demonstrate that even minimal or comedic reviews act as a memory reconstructive function. For instance, one user wrote a one-sentence review of *Parasite* (2019): "This movie ruined automatic sensor lights for me." That one-liner review encodes a vivid recollection of an experience that influences the formation and retrieval of what Moliner-Tena et al. (2023) refer to as flashbulb events.

User hermitmaxxr2000's review of the movie *Blow* (2001) explicitly reflects on the relationship between a user's judgment and the general aggregated ratings:

"...56% rotten tomatoes and 3.5 Letterboxd. ya'll the reason we can't have nice things (cinema)" - user hermitmaxxr2000's review of *Blow* (2001)

Here, the review reconstructs the film's meaning against perceived consensus. The reviewer positions himself as a discerning viewer who appreciates what "ya'll" do not. Hence, the review functions as reconstruction of a memory of the film, instilling the emotions, which emerged when compiling the review.

We also found other confirming examples of humorous encoding in action:

"Do you guys think he freaks his shit with the hand that says love or hate?" - user elementarii's review of *The Night of the Hunter* (1955)

User elementarii described the particular review as "not very deep," but admitted that it made them laugh to have that thought. The joke is the memory. Hence, at the time reviewers review, they might not recall the plot perfectly, but that question will remain alive and the film experience can be reimagined later on.

How Memory Reconstruction Constructs Consumer Experiences

Analysis theme 2 supports the memory reconstruction transformational outcome of the proposed model (Figure 1), in that memory reconstruction is central to how consumer identities are formed, conserved and shared. Our analysis showed how the continuation of a reviewing practice

can enhance a consumer's ability to consolidate opinions, anchor them in a personal timeline, and express them in an acceptable form.

The movie consumption experience altering effects induced by reviewing are backed up in our analysis by concepts from autobiographical memory theory. Not only did our cohort of reviewers better remember their art consumption experience upon leaving a review, they are also developing a timeline of themselves as movie consumers. The changing nature of consumer/reviewer identities are encapsulated on their Letterboxd profiles, which gives credence to the idea that Consumer Ideologies (CI) (Arnould & Thompson, 2005) are being continuously developed through the reviewing process and by consumers maturing as reviewers.

Theme 3: Reviewing as Performance of Identity and Community

In our analysis, we observed a multitude of ways in which online reviewing expresses social performances of identity and community culture. Across interview participants distinct identities were performed in different ways, ranging from community oriented authenticity to deliberate privacy to ironic detachment. Our findings cover different methods of positioning oneself within the Letterboxd consumption world, and how the culture of the platform shapes how movie consumers want to be perceived amongst peers.

Performing Authenticity

Many of the interview participants claimed that for them there is no inherent intention to "seek likes" and Letterboxd functions more as a "personal journal." Nevertheless, the analysed reviews were filled with direct addresses to readers, rhetorical questions, and explicit engagement with community discourse. This highlights the inescapability of performance within public reviewing practices, wherein supposedly private reflections become shaped by the awareness of reaching out to an online audience.

One concern that emerged from exposure to other reviewers' opinions was a fear of interpretive inauthenticity. User mvrtsysy described uncertainty over whether their thoughts were genuinely their own after being exposed to numerous existing opinions and interpretations. If that feeling persisted, they would sometimes feel reluctant to even write the review altogether:

"Sometimes I hold myself back because so many people have already written it, and I feel like my thoughts are not authentic." - user mvrtsysy

This suggests that the feedback loop created through reviewing can also become directed toward the self, not only toward the artwork or the audience. Letterboxd users consume not only films, but also pre-existing interpretations. The abundance of available personal reviews can destabilize their confidence in the originality of their reactions, introducing a form of meta-cognition that shifts from "What do I think?" to "Did I actually think it myself?". Therefore, reviewing can

shape not only how consumers experience film, but also how they experience themselves as interpreters of it.

Other participants also expressed a fear of redundancy, which can be interpreted as a direct consequence of audience awareness. The imagined community is the benchmark against which users measure their performance authenticity.

"What was I going to say about Forrest Gump that hasn't been said?" - user joyplague

Seemingly, it is the expansiveness of the Letterboxd consumption world that creates the pressure toward originality. To be worthwhile or necessary, a review must add something new to the conversation. This pressure is distinctly a social constraint, which emerges from the communal nature of the platform and constant exposure to existing interpretations. The social pressure attached to acting as an early interpreter appeared to further deepen consumption experience. Reviewing requires both an individual reflective process, as well as a social act of cultural mediation. Therefore, each reviewer is affected by the larger marketplace culture, and has an active role in shaping how films are interpreted within it.

Performing Taste and Cinephilic Legitimacy

Interview participants also reflected on authenticity through their relationship to cinephilic norms and reviewer legitimacy. Some users expressed the pressure of engaging with films, especially highly critically acclaimed ones, in the "correct" way. It became particularly visible the moment participants gained larger audiences and became more conscious about the weight their voice would carry as cultural value.

User elementarii described how she managed to break this cycle and gradually distanced herself from viewing films through a critic-oriented lens:

"I was really watching it like a critic, and it became very unenjoyable." - user elementarii

They explained that instead of pressuring herself to constantly consume "really good films" or "very highbrow cinema," they began selecting films based on mood and personal enjoyment. Authenticity was therefore expressed through resisting institutionalized critic norms and allowing being emotionally subjective in the viewing experience.

At the same time, other participants remained aware of the broader cinephilic value systems. Especially, when reviewing culturally significant films, they expressed a tension between natural reactions and the mirrored cinephilic legitimacy. User dila_ern described questioning her own rating after giving an acclaimed classic the same score as a more widely discredited film:

"Why did I give that great classic the same amount of stars as The Housemaid?" - user dila_ern

The need to revisit that evaluation shows how communal standards can shape perceptions of what makes a "valid" reaction. This introduces the notion of "cinephilic hive mindset," where the reviews become intertwined with what the reviewer believes a valid cinematic critique is.

"i don't see the hype tbh SOZ :DDD storywise lacking." - user hermitmaxxr2000's review of *Ghost in the Shell* (1995)

Participants negotiated their cinephile identity in different, sometimes opposing ways. User elementarii associated the label with people who "really know what they're talking about" or possess stronger historical and analytical knowledge of cinema, eventually distancing herself from the identity at all:

"I don't think I would apply that term to myself anymore really. I just would say that I love movies." - user elementarii

In contrast, other participants openly embraced the cinephile identity. User heythisisjames described cinephilia less through expertise or very refined taste, and more as cinema becoming "a significant part" of one's life:

"As soon as you step outside of that norm, you're kind of entering that field." - user heythisisjames

These contrasting views demonstrate that authenticity within the Letterboxd consumption world is not fixed. While some participants pursued authenticity through resisting critic norms, others expressed it opposingly through highly intentional engagement with cinema.

Ultimately, reviewers collectively shape and reproduce the communal understanding of what counts as valuable criticism, "good taste," or legitimate engagement with film. This closely aligns with Consumer Ideology and Marketplace Culture theory: how reviewers create cinephilic norms, follow them, negotiate them, and reinforce them in the end through participation in Letterboxd consumption culture. A performance of authenticity in reviews is then also juxtaposed with a rejection or a validation of the cinephilic identity.

Performing Privacy

Other participants represent the opposite side of online reviewing, specifically a performance of privacy within a public platform (e.g., "I follow only close friends").

"I don't really care about the community value of Letterboxd at all … it's purely for me, it's just my diary." - anonymous user

A performance of privacy is itself a recognizable role within the consumption world. We detected a pattern of reviewers who were akin to lone archivists, using the platform as a tool,

instead of a social space. Nevertheless, even this rejection of community is a form of positioning since these reviewers rarely address an audience, instead opting for signaling a membership in an *in-group* rather than the broader platform.

There are reviewers who occupy a middle ground between the two extremes, valuing some communal aspects:

"For me, it's not so much the cinephile communal aspect, or like the Letterboxd communal aspect, like the digital one, more like the, if you meet people in real life who ... are connected to it." - user hermitmaxxr2000

A distinction between digital community and real-life cultural participation is an important nuance. Although some reviewers do seek validation on the online platform, others use the platform as a way to express their identity to others offline. Reviewers who felt a connection between their online and offline identities expressed a feeling of "maturing" as a reviewer and person, when writing about the artwork.

Performing Comedy, Relatability and Helpfulness

Some reviewers were also overtly performative, meaning that their reviews functioned as addresses to specific audiences, a generic "reader" who will appreciate a carefully crafted take on a movie.

"*My fragile identity is very closely tied with comedy no matter the situation, and my reviews reflect that."* - anonymous user

These reviewers communicate through memes, ironic undercutting, and pop culture references. Their humor functions as a mask for genuine passion:

"I try to be easy going but I am also very passionate. To balance that I tend to be quite ironic." - anonymous user

On occasion users also exhibited a literal review persona, wherein relatability to the reader of the review was key. User someone272 considers reviews to be inherently practical, functioning as recommendations. User joyplague also supports this idea, saying that his reviews are at times a guide to readers. Helpfulness is hence also a guiding factor for some reviews, but this is more apparent in retail goods reviews (e.g., Babić Rosario et al., 2020).

How Reviewing Performs Identities and Constructs Consumption Worlds

The practice of reviewing allowed our studied cohort of Letterboxd reviewers to express their identities within a consumption world, thereby influencing Marketplace Cultures. Across our sample of Letterboxd reviewers a theme of identity performances was apparent, even though

unintentional at times. The ways in which these performances unfold were radically different, but these individual reviewer identities are the building blocks for constructing and maintaining the consumption world of Letterboxd. As Arnould and Thompson (2005) argue, marketplace cultures are not static, instead they are continuously produced and reproduced through the practices of consumers. Each review, whether authentic, private, comedic, or helpful, contributes to the shared zeitgeist of acceptable ways to be a film reviewer. Following that same logic, over time, these individual performances become norms and status systems.

Lastly, and perhaps most importantly, the performance of identity does not occur in a vacuum. Reviewing is shaped by the material affordances of the platform (e.g., the star rating system, the comment section, the ability to follow other users) and also by the perceived existence of an audience. Even when reviewers claim to ignore that audience, they are nonetheless responding to it. This reciprocative relationship between individual performance and collective structure is how consumption worlds are built, contested, and transformed.

Discussion

This thesis set out to answer the question: How does the practice of online reviewing affect movie consumption experiences? Our analysis of Letterboxd reviews and user interviews explained how an active online reviewing practice can induce transformational outcomes, which we discuss in relation to both theoretical and practical implications, as well as limitations and future research.

Eudaimonic Benefits of Online Movie Reviewing

In our first analysis theme we integrate our findings into the Figure 1 model and theorize how reviewing induced affective and cognitive prolongation extends engagement with a movie consumption experience. Our findings did not indicate that a reviewing practice has a necessarily positive effect on the consumption experience. However, critical understanding is necessary to reach conclusive, articulated movie reviews, which does entail the development of propositional reasoning.

Even comedic or one-sentence reviews forced propositional reasoning in order to answer the question: “What did I think and why?” This supports the APE model’s claim that explicit evaluation requires validation of associative inputs (Gawronski & Bodenhausen, 2006). Over time, a system of propositional reasoning is developed, as reviewers become more attentive and analytically self-aware during the viewing itself.

The consumption orientations, as discussed by Schmitt et al. (2022), help us to systematize the varied reviewing orientations we observed. *Reconnection* was exhibited by reviewers who

embraced Letterboxd's reviewing culture non-reflectively, using it as a personal diary *Alienation* was expressed as dissatisfaction with the platform's commercial pressures and with the perceived expectation for originality. *Engagement* was evident in reviewers who strategically craft reviews for social validation, and *activism* in those who deliberately reject community norms. However, our findings of consumption orientations are not permanent nor rigid, since reviewers can shift their consumer identities over time or across contexts. This reflects the dialectic nature of consumption ideology (Žižek, 1997).

Based on our findings it is possible to discuss the eudaimonic benefits of movie reviewing. As previously covered by Schneider et al. (2021), entertainment experiences can elicit happiness from meaning and self-realization. When a movie reviewing practice develops consumers' propositional reasoning, reviewers are able to understand and create authentic self-identities. The realization and enactment of unique consumption preferences through movie reviewing is what we think actualizes the perceived eudaimonic benefits.

Reviews As Temporal Anchors of Past Self-Identities

Our second analysis theme covered how reviewing elicits the creation of temporal anchors and encapsulates past self-identities within archived reviews. Memory decay was not necessarily prevented through reviewing, but previous lines of thinking were made visible to movie consumers as their archive of reviews. Past movie consumption experiences were not necessarily more vivid/memorable due to reviewing, but the sharing of movie experiences publicly did necessitate a reconstruction of episodic traces.

Our findings signify the importance of autobiographical memory theory and Consumer Identity Projects in movie marketing research. A continuous reviewing practice crystallizes the self-identity of a movie consumer into a certain point in time. Since reviewers have the ability to revisit their old reviews, they are able to relive not only the specific movie experience but also a sense of their past selves. An active reviewing is then directly related to memory reconstruction and identity work, as it shows the development of propositional reasoning through time.

The Co-Creation of a Consumption World Through Online Reviewing

Our third analysis theme relates to how marketplace cultures and consumer ideologies are being actively co-created. The Letterboxd platform, as the consumption world, is where perceived norms (e.g., originality, authenticity, humour) are performed. Each new review is a tiny drop in the ocean of the established Letterboxd reviewing culture and reviewers are consistently navigating within the expanse of different review ideologies. This was conveyed by interviewees as a sense of pressure to avoid redundancy or to craft distinct voices that are held to sensed standards.

The nature of our findings brings into question why there is such limited marketing research on the CCT aspects of online movie reviewing. Researching the consumer experience effects of online movie reviewing might not necessarily increase box office outcomes, but still offer insights into the cultural aspects of media consumption. While we acknowledge our qualitative findings are contingent on the theories we have used in Figure 1, our perceived transformational outcomes of online movie reviewing still warrant an increased academic interest.

Theoretical Contributions

A major theoretical contribution of our thesis is the integration of CCT and the APE model, where the multi-level framework we created in Figure 1 connects macro-level consumer culture theories with micro-level psychological processes. In respect to CCT, Thompson (2024, p. 565) has advocated for "ontological reconfigurations of established theorizations," which is exactly what we set out to accomplish. We attempt to reframe reviewing as a value-creating process for movie consumers, not just as predictive outputs for box-office forecasting (e.g., Chintagunta et al., 2010; Moon et al., 2010). Our findings show that a reviewing practice is able to provide movie consumers personal value, which shifts the focus of art marketing research from financial outcomes to experiential outcomes.

Our thesis also addresses Schneider et al.'s (2021, p. 598) observation that even though "the APE model has been cited over 2,000 times in the last ten years" there has been no empirical study (to our knowledge) that has applied the model to primary data collected from movie consumers. While we acknowledge movie consumption experiences are a narrow subsection of the entirety of consumer evaluations, this thesis still contributes to popularizing the use of the APE model in art marketing research.

Lastly, this thesis confirms the importance of memory reconstruction in understanding art consumption experience. While memory theory has been studied extensively in both psychology and marketing (Jonas et al., 2023), we demonstrate its specific mechanisms in movie consumption experiences; mainly rewriting significance, temporal anchoring, and humorous encoding. While our findings are initial and quite heavily dependent on the theoretical framework, they still warrant further academic investigation.

Practical Implications

In our set-out research aims we theorized how the knowledge we generate could benefit different stakeholders, such as online review platforms. From our findings, we confirmed the importance of co-creation when it comes to consumer ideologies and marketplace cultures (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). These aspects are crucial to the success of online review platforms, since they

evoke activity within the user base. Therefore, encouraging the use of reflective writing features (e.g., prompts, personal year-in-review summaries, private notes) may deepen user engagement more than aggregated star ratings.

Movie marketers can also benefit from considering how user reviews have the capacity to affect consumption experiences by creating personal value through evaluation (as theorized by Moliner-Tena et al., 2023). Dedicated movie reviewers consider reviewing as part of the consumption experience itself and have a highly developed sense of their reviewer identity. This relates to how consumption choices are made, since the development of propositional reasoning creates a stronger sense of personal tastes. Hence, movie marketers can encourage an active reviewing practice to increase the personal investment of movie consumers, who in turn are more vocal about their opinions (leading to financial outcomes).

Lastly, cultural institutions can benefit from the knowledge of how written reviews (even short ones) can transform passive fleeting consumption experiences into actualized personal connections. By developing the propositional reasoning prowess of consumers through reviewing, cultural institutions can further promote aesthetic literacy of the public.

Limitations and Future Research

There are several limitations that have to be considered when interpreting our findings, such as our focus on one platform and only on one art form. While there are many forms of art and online review platforms, we studied only movie reviewing in the context of Letterboxd. Future research can compare reviewing practices on other prevalent platforms or across art forms (e.g., music, literature, gaming).

We also employed a singular perspective, as we focused only on the act of reviewing, not the effect of reviews on readers. This is a significant limitation as in art consumers can be significantly influenced by the diaspora of different previous opinions. Future studies could investigate how reading reviews alters consumption experiences (e.g., reviewing vs. non-reviewing audiences).

Our experiential findings are completely qualitative in nature and are, therefore, not quantifiable or generalizable. Mixed-methods research could aim to measure correlations between reviewing frequency, memory retention, as well as use big data to quantify more specific consumer sentiments.

We acknowledge that the model we created makes the assumption that reviewing is transformative for all engaged reviewers and that our sample skewed toward highly engaged users. It is possible that for a significant subset of movie consumers, reviewing produces no transformation, and our created model does not account for such cases. Future research can furthermore explore what distinguishes reviewers who experience transformational outcomes from those who do not.

Our findings could have also been enhanced if our thesis employed a longitudinal research design. We only studied reviewers who already had some sort of a Letterboxd review practice, which did not allow us to examine how starting a review practice changes how movie consumption experiences. A future study could employ a longitudinal research design, wherein participants are recruited to keep a review practice for some span of time. The results can then better ascertain whether starting a reviewing practice changes consumption experience.

Conclusion

This thesis' aim was to understand how the practice of online reviewing affects movie consumption experiences. Through netnographic analysis of 260 Letterboxd reviews and semi-structured interviews with 13 active users, three transformational outcomes were discussed.

First, reviewing extends and deepens the consumption experience. Across participants, the act of writing a review prolonged engagement with the film, transforming passive viewing into personal meaning-making. This deepening occurred through affective (emotional catharsis and closure) and cognitive (forced reflection and over-analysis) prolongation of the movie experience. The valence effect of reviewing on the movie consumption experience was varied, as some reviewers reported intensified enjoyment, while others found that further critical thinking diminished initial positive reactions.

Second, reviewing forces the reconstruction of memory and meaning. Reviews have the ability to function as temporal anchors, allowing reviewers to revisit a movie experience, as well as their past selves at specific moments in time. Reviewed films are generally remembered better than unreviewed ones, but more emotionally vivid reviews might induce memory decay due to interference (Moliner-Tena et al., 2023).

Third, online movie reviewing performs and affects consumer identities and ideologies. Performances range from seeking authenticity and originality within the community to rejecting the community entirely, performing comedy for a generic audience, or asserting privacy as a

deliberate positioning strategy. These individual performances collectively constitute and reproduce the marketplace culture of Letterboxd.

Returning to the central research question, this thesis demonstrates that the act of reviewing alters the art consumption experience in three interrelated ways: it prolongs engagement, affects memories of consumption, and performs/shapes identity. These aspects of online reviewing operate simultaneously and reinforce one another, as a reviewer who writes to process emotions also inevitably reshapes their memory of the film and performs a version of their cinephile self for an online audience.

Consequently, our analysis gives support to Arnould & Thompson's (2015, p. 15) claim that "the theoretical pairing of commerce and culture" offers "distinctive contributions to the broader interdisciplinary conversation concerning consumption and society." Reviewers described reviews as a constitutive part of how they consumed movies and this suggests that art consumption is not complete after the viewing experience. Art consumption requires articulation and, therefore, reviewing is not an accessory to art consumption but a constitutive part of it.

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Appendix 1.

Interview Questions

The following semi-structured interview guide was used for all 13 participants.

1. Can you tell me a bit about yourself as a film viewer? How would you describe your relationship with movies?

2. How long have you been using Letterboxd, and what initially drew you to the platform?

3. Approximately how many films do you watch in a typical month, and how many of those do you review?

4. Would you consider yourself a cinephile? If so, what does that term mean to you?

5. Can you walk me through your thought process immediately after finishing a film, and then while you are writing a review?

6. Does the awareness that you will be writing a review change how you watch a film? If so, how?

7. When do you typically write your reviews – right after watching, the next day, or later? Does timing matter?

8. Can you describe a recent review you wrote? What film was it, and what was your process for writing about it?

9. Do you ever start writing and realise your feelings about the film are different than you initially thought?

10. How much time do you typically spend crafting a review?

11. How does writing down your thoughts affect your overall feeling about the film, compared to if you had just watched it and moved on?

12. Have you ever had an experience where writing a review changed your opinion of a film – making you like it more, less, or something else?
13. Do you find that some films stay with you longer because you reviewed them? Can you give an example?

14. Have you ever disagreed with your past self when rereading an old review?

15. When you watch a film, do you trust your immediate emotional reactions, or do you find yourself questioning them?

16. Can you describe a time when your gut feeling about a film was different from the review you ended up writing?

17. How much of your review is about how the film made you feel versus how well it was it made?

18. Would you say your reviews are a form of self-expression? What do you feel your reviews say about you as a person or as a film fan?

19. Have your reviews changed over time? Have you developed a distinct style or voice?

20. Do you ever hold back in reviews (positive or negative) because of how you might be perceived by others?

21. When someone likes or comments on your review, how does that feel? Does it affect how you review in the future?

22. Do you have a review that you are particularly proud of? What makes it special?

23. Do you feel your reviews contribute to a larger conversation? How important is community engagement to you?

24. Do you follow any specific reviewers? Are there people whose opinion you particularly value or seek out?

25. Have you ever changed your mind about a film because of someone else's review or a discussion on the platform?

26. What does Letterboxd offer that watching films alone or discussing them with Friends do not?

27. If Letterboxd suddenly shut down tomorrow, what would you miss most about your reviewing practice? What would you do?

28. Why do you keep reviewing? What does it do for you that just watching films does not?

29. If you were to describe what reviewing adds to your life in your own words, What would you say?

30. Would you say reviewing is a habit, a hobby, a passion, or something else entirely?

Appendix 2.

Literature Search Description

The academic literature used in this thesis was searched for through Google Scholar, Scopus and the University of Gothenburg Library search. The primary search keywords used were "Consumer Culture Theory OR CCT," “consumer evaluations,” "movie reviews OR consumer reviews,” "online reviews AND art consumption," "netnography," and "memory reconstruction." Searches were conducted between January and April 2026. Boolean operators (AND, OR, quotation marks) were used to combine terms. Backward and forward citation tracking was employed from seminal sources (Arnould & Thompson, 2005; Gawronski & Bodenhausen, 2006), using Scopus and Connected Papers as discovery tools. Inclusion was limited to peer-reviewed English-language journal articles, books, and relevant methodological sources. Previous movie marketing research studies on online reviewing were used only to establish the research gap and were not used for theoretical development.